Physical Appearance and Elections: An Inequality Perspective

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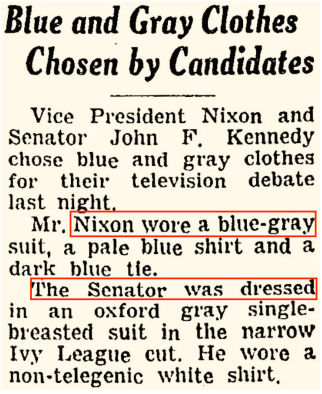
TV, Looks and Political Branding

- During the 1950s and the 1960s, TV gets massively introduced in American homes.
- This opened up new possibilities for **political campaigning**.



TV, Looks and Political Branding

- The **first televised presidential debate** was in 1960: Nixon vs. Kennedy.
- For the first time, make up, posture, clothing (**physical appearance!**) began to matter.



Blue and Gray Clothes Chosen by Candidates

Vice President Nixon and Senator John F. Kennedy chose blue and gray clothes for their television debate last night.

Mr. Nixon wore a blue-gray suit, a pale blue shirt and a dark blue tie.

The Senator was dressed in an oxford gray single-breasted suit in the narrow Ivy League cut. He wore a non-telegenic white shirt.

The Times (London 1960).

Nixon-Kennedy 1960 Debate

- Nixon's "five-o'clock shadow" negatively affected his evaluation.

  Mattes et. al (2010).

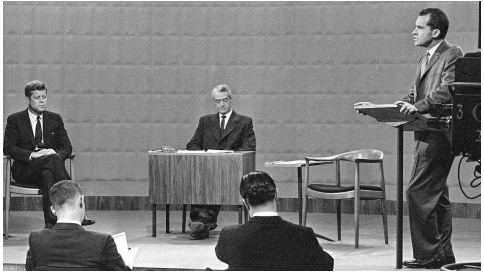


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Nixon-Kennedy 1960 Debate

- Nixon's "five-o'clock shadow" negatively affected his evaluation.

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- Nixon's posture didn't look "presidential."
- Nixon was all sweaty.

  Stockemer and Praino (2019).



Good-looking Candidates do Better in Elections

- We know that better-looking candidates are more likely to win elections.
- "**Voters vote beautiful**" (Efrain and Patterson, 1974) because "**beautiful is good**" (Dion et al., 1972).



"What Are Good-Looking Candidates?" (Stockemer and Praino, 2019)

What About Wealthy-looking or Poor-looking Candidates?

- However, what happens when candidates look poor/wealthy, does that affect their chances of getting elected?

✓ This questions is relevant because it touches upon issues of social stratification and voting choices.

Inequality Perspective: Social Stratification and Elections

- **Identify** that the literature *only* looks at candidate attractiveness, which is just *one* dimension of physical appearance.
- **Beyond attractiveness** and explore the degree in which a candidate's **social class** affects the number of votes received.
- **Empirics**: we exploit a novel data set of candidate physical appearances (2017 Finnish Municipal Elections).
- **(*Uncomfortable*) results**

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- **(*Uncomfortable*) results**: Finns systematically...
  1. Vote less for **working-class *looking*** candidates, and
  2. the fx's are stronger for **female** candidates.

Political Psychology: Heuristics

- A candidate's **physical appearance** is "the most important" (Lau & Redlawsk 2001) and the "most obvious and accessible" (Dion et al. 1972) *heuristic* available to voters (Stockemer & Praino 2017).

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- **Heuristics** are cognitive devices that allow **reasonable voting decision-making with minimal effort** (Lau & Redlawsk 2001 and Tversky & Kahneman 1973).
- Thus, "voters vote beautiful" (Efrain & Patterson 1974) because attractive candidates "are more likely to be attributed the qualities associated with successful politicians" (Stockemer & Praino 2019).

Status Expectations Theory

- Physical attractiveness is considered a similar status characteristic as gender or occupation.

✓ We extend this concept to cues of **occupation** as a **status** characteristic.

Argument

We argue that information about candidates' **occupations** combined with information about candidates' **physical appearance**, function as **cues of status** that have an effect on **voting choices** in low-information elections.

In simple...

Candidates that **look like** and actually **are** wealthy (poor) will do better (worse) in elections.

Finland as a Hard Case

- We follow a "**least-likely case design**" (Levy 2008). Finland has been consistently considered as:
  - A 'democratic' (Polity-V).
  - An 'economic egalitarian' (Waltl 2022).
  - A 'gender egalitarian.'
  - A 'social-mobility prone' country (Erola 2009).
- Thus, it should be **hard to find** a **correlation** between class-congruent use of status symbols and **voting**.

...and yet, we *do*.

Campaigns: Plain, Simple and Fair

- **Public posters**:
  - Show candidate face, party and occupation.
  - Shown in city centers, bus stops, *and* voting booths!
- Municipalities *must* provide the *same* number of poster slots for all parties.



Finnish Poster Displaying Candidates' Faces, Parties and Occupations

2017 Municipal Elections: Candidate Data

- **Ministry of Justice**: candidate's picture, party, occupation, district and number of votes received.
- **Sample**: randomly selected **1,500 candidate head shots**. Universe 33,618; possible 10,000.
- **Occupation and social class**: European Socio-economic Classification, recoded each candidate's occupation (upper, middle and working class).

Novel Raters Data

- Collected data from 7,920 randomly selected Finnish-speaking Finns.
- **Task**: evaluated a random sample of candidate photographs (N∼50) according to four items.
- **Items**:
  1. **Occupation-Appearance congruence.** *Does this person look like the profession he/she is declaring?*
  2. **Attractiveness.**
  3. **Masculinity.**
  4. **Femininity.**

▸ show table with items ▸ show distributions ▸ show balance plot

Functional Form and Model

$$
\begin{aligned}
Y_i = \text{Votes}_i &\sim \texttt{Poisson} \\
\log(\text{Votes}_i) &= \beta_1 \text{Occupation-Appearance Congruence}_i \times \text{Social Class}_i + \\
&\quad \beta_2 \text{Age}_i + \\
&\quad \gamma 1 \text{Party}_i + \\
&\quad \gamma 2 \text{City}_i + \\
&\quad \boldsymbol{\Theta}_i
\end{aligned}
$$

- In $\boldsymbol{\Theta}$ we **also control for**: Attractiveness_i, Masculinity_i and Femininity_i.
- Full, but also **partition the data** (male & female).
- We focus on the **marginal effects** of the interaction term.

show regression table

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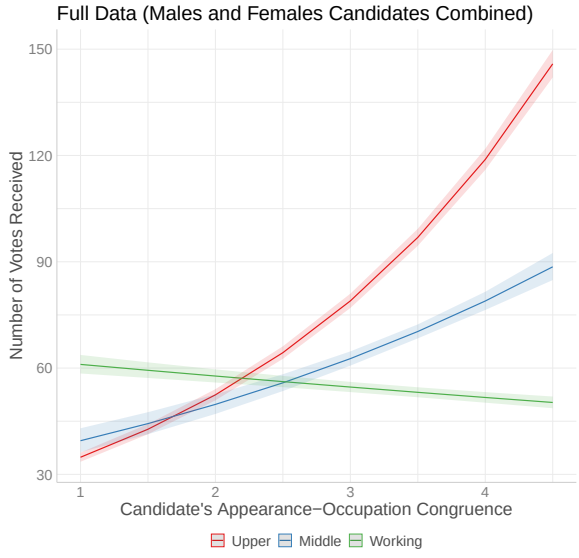
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Predicted Probabilities Table

Candidate's Gender	Status	$\hat{\text{Votes}}$	95% CI	
Female	Don't look like working class	154	144	165
	Look a lot like working class	99	94	104
Male	Don't look like working class	49	46	51
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Main Results

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- **Female** candidates:
  - Systematic electoral penalty when they **look like** working-class individuals.
  - **Marginal change** represents a -36%*** votes!
- **Male** candidates:
  - *Don't* experience the same electoral penalty: it does *not* matter (electorally) if a male candidate looks working-class.

Main Takeaways

- ✓ Considered **the use of heuristics in elections** and the concept of **"status" in expectation states theory**.
- ✓ Selected the ***unlikely* case** of the 2017 Finnish Municipal Elections.
- ✓ Exploited a **novel representative data set** of candidates' physical appearances.
- ✓ Proposed an alternative explanation for **voting** not based on attractiveness but on **occupation-appearance congruence** and **social stratification**.
- ✓ Female candidates experience a systematic **electoral penalty** when they **look working-class**.

Thank you



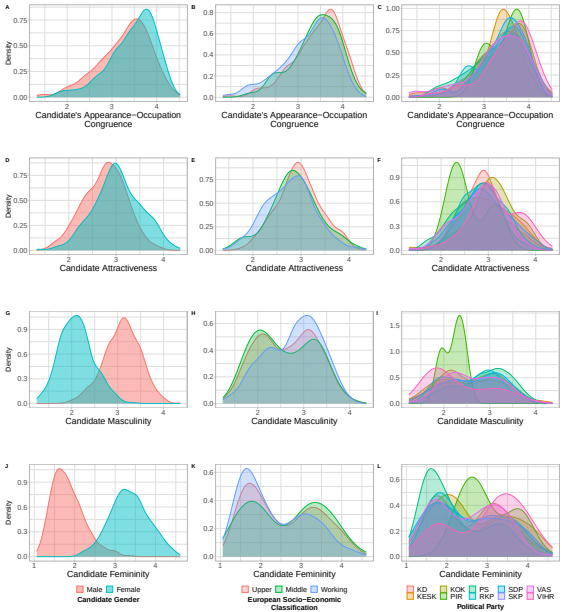
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Raters Data: Questions and Answer Set

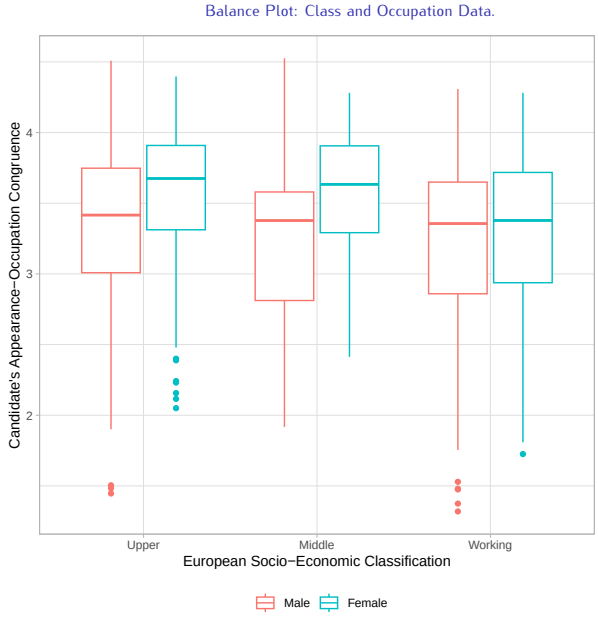
Sample	Attribute	Question	Answer Set
1	Occupation-Appearance Congruence	To what extent does this person respond to your image of someone working in [occupation]?	5=Perfectly responds to my image, 4=Responds well to my image, 3=Somewhat responds to my image, 2=Does not respond to my image well, 1=Does not respond to my image at all.
2	Attractiveness	In your opinion, how attractive does this person look, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	5=very attractive, 4=more attractive than the average, 3=average, 2=below average, 1=well below average (Griffin and Langois 2006; Bono et al. 2017; Tu, Gilbert and Bono 2021)
3	Masculinity	To what extent do you think this person looks masculine, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	1=not masculine at all, to 5=very masculine (e.g., Hoss et al. 2005).
4	Femininity	To what extent do you think this person looks feminine, as compared to others of the same age and gender?	1=not feminine at all, to 5=very feminine.

go back

Distributions of Candidate Physical Appearance Indicators.



go back


Balance Plot: Class and Occupation Data.
Candidate's Appearance−Occupation Congruence
4
3
2
Upper
Middle
Working
European Socio−Economic Classification
Male
Female

go back

Table: Statistical Models

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
	Full	Male	Female	Full	Full	Full	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female
Intercept	4.49***	2.58***	6.17***	2.11***	4.27***	2.15***	−0.25**	3.24***	2.50***	2.98***	0.17	2.80***
	(0.05)	(0.08)	(0.07)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.08)
Appearance-Occupation Congruence	0.41***	0.59***	0.28***	0.25***	0.42***	0.26***	0.37***	0.22***	0.59***	0.28***	0.37***	0.24***
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Middle Class	0.30***	0.81***	−0.05	0.41***	0.23***	0.31***	0.54***	0.12	0.77***	0.18	0.75***	0.16
	(0.06)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.08)	(0.11)	(0.08)	(0.11)
Working Class	1.03***	1.59***	0.70***	0.49***	1.07***	0.58***	0.95***	0.23***	1.59***	0.32***	0.86***	0.19**
	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.04)	(0.07)
Age	−0.02***	−0.01***	−0.03***	−0.00***	−0.02***	−0.01***	0.00***	−0.01***	−0.01***	−0.02***	0.01***	−0.01***
	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)
Appearance-Occupation Congruence X Middle Class	−0.18***	−0.34***	−0.11***	−0.20***	−0.16***	−0.17***	−0.22***	−0.17***	−0.33***	−0.19***	−0.28***	−0.18***
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.03)
Appearance-Occupation Congruence X Working Class	−0.46***	−0.61***	−0.43***	−0.28***	−0.48***	−0.31***	−0.39***	−0.28***	−0.62***	−0.29***	−0.35***	−0.27***
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.01)	(0.02)
Attractiveness				0.76***		0.89***	1.00***	0.72***			1.08***	0.53***
				(0.01)		(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)			(0.01)	(0.01)
Masculinity					0.09***				0.04***		−0.28***	
					(0.00)				(0.01)		(0.01)	
Femininity						−0.15***				0.68***		0.26***
						(0.00)				(0.01)		(0.02)
AIC	287653.94	170596.79	79111.45	267973.43	287029.77	265328.79	154959.12	73290.19	170577.24	74331.79	153861.01	73001.39
BIC	288886.12	171561.82	79936.45	269210.66	288267.17	266571.24	155928.83	74119.20	171546.96	75161.13	154835.41	73834.74
Log Likelihood	−143590.97	−85092.40	−39365.73	−133749.72	−143277.88	−132426.40	−77272.56	−36454.09	−85081.62	−36974.89	−76722.51	−36308.70
Deviance	278666.41	165250.11	75150.60	258990.24	278040.23	256343.60	149610.43	69333.68	165228.56	70368.94	148510.33	69042.88
Num. obs.	1368	800	568	1367	1368	1367	800	567	800	568	800	567

$^{***}p < 0.001$; $^{**}p < 0.01$; $^{*}p < 0.05$.

Dependent variable is the number of votes each candidate received. City fixed effects and party variables omitted. The reference category in the ESEC variable is 'Upper Class.' Given the symmetry of the derivatives, changing the reference category does not alter the interpretation of the results. Functional form is Poisson regression for all models.

go back